Engine fix · accent / on-accent pairing

Text that survives a pale accent.

Every accent-filled surface now pairs with its curated `--on-accent` ink — readable on a near-black lime, a warm cream, or a cool slate, in both modes.

DECISION REQUIRED

Build the data layer or buy it?

Both paths are viable. The difference is where we spend the next 18 months.

BUILD IN-HOUSE

- Full control over schema and roadmap
- 2–3 engineer-quarters to reach feature parity
- Ongoing maintenance burden stays internal

BUY + CONFIGURE

- Ship in 6 weeks, not 9 months
- Engineering capacity redirects to product features
- Exit risk manageable — export contractually guaranteed

RECOMMENDATION

Buy the infrastructure. Build the differentiation. Revisit in 24 months.

The fix has four moving parts.

1

One source of truth

`--on-accent` is curated per theme for AAA contrast against that theme's accent, in both light and dark.

2

Derived muted tiers

Secondary, ghost, and watermark inks mix down from `--on-accent` by opacity — no white-on-pale collisions.

3

Consumers realigned

The verdict bar and pinned tag now read the pair instead of a fixed light ink.

4

Projected to the web

The site palette generator ships `--on-accent`, so the landing CTA matches the deck.

How the accent ink resolves.

1

Theme sets accent

A near-black, a cream, a lime — whatever the brand calls for

2

Theme pairs on-accent

The contrast partner, tuned to AAA against that accent

3

Tiers derive

Secondary / ghost / watermark mix down by opacity

4

Consumer fills

Any surface using var(--accent) paints text from the pair

T

On-accent rail

The accent rail proves it

Accent rail · split-panel watermark

Where the pairing shows

The left rail fills with the raw accent. Its eyebrow rides `--on-accent` at full strength and the letterform watermark rides `--on-accent-watermark`, so the rail stays legible on a pale canvas.

1. **Eyebrow**
   Reads at `--on-accent` — the curated ink itself. A muted derivation would spend the AA margin that curation buys, so size and weight carry the step down instead.
2. **Watermark**
   The oversized glyph sits at 12% and never fights the content.
3. **Numerals**
   Each counter chip fills with accent and stamps `--on-accent`.

One pair, every palette

Curated once. Readable everywhere.

KEY INSIGHT

Reuse the ink the theme already trusts.